

3.6 Topic 4: Superpower Geographies

Power

Power — both economic and political — is not evenly distributed. Some nations and players have a disproportionate influence over regional and global decision making, whereas others work within systems they have little influence over. The geography of power has developed over time, and continues to change. Some nations gain power and influence, while others lose it. Equally the nature of power has changed, from direct to more subtle control; through trade, culture, flows of capital and resources.

Rising superpowers

The economic rise of the BRICs (Brazil, Russia, India and China) brings economic benefits to many, but also potential economic costs to the 'older' superpowers (the USA and the EU), as well as having environmental and resource implications. In an increasingly globalised and inter-dependent world, it is possible that tensions will emerge as power continues to shift.

1 Superpower geographies

Enquiry question: *Who are the superpowers and how does their power develop over time?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ The concept of a 'superpower' has developed to include economic, cultural, military and geographical influence, for example the development of the USA and USSR.	■ Developing an awareness of how superpowers can be defined by their range of influences.
■ The geography of power and international influence can be seen through geographical patterns of military reach, trade and cultural dominance.	■ Investigating the mechanisms and processes that maintain power.
■ Patterns of power change over time, and can be illustrated through a study of the decline of the British Empire and the reasons for the collapse of communism, versus the factors behind the rise of emergent superpowers such as China and the EU.	■ Investigating how and why superpower status develops over time, recognising that power and influence change, and that influence may wane as new powers emerge.

■ There are differences in the influence of emerging powers (the BRICs) versus existing superpowers (the USA) in terms of regional and global influence; these can be explained through theoretical frameworks such as World Systems Theory and Dependency Theory. A study of India and China might be undertaken to draw out contrasts between the two countries.	■ Exploring the current balance between superpowers and developing an overview of the relationships between them, within a theoretical framework.
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2 The role of superpowers

Enquiry question: *What impacts and influence do superpowers have?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ Power can be maintained directly or indirectly; colonial direct rule and its legacy versus neo-colonial models of indirect influence; for instance trade, aid and debt.	■ Exploring contrasting mechanisms of power and how the influence of superpowers has evolved from largely direct control to largely, but not exclusively, indirect forms of control.
■ Superpowers play a key role in international decision-making, policy and action through direct and indirect processes (the UN, G8, NATO, the EU, the Davos group).	■ Examining ways in which superpowers use and maintain their role as global powerbrokers.
■ Control of trade, in terms of generating wealth, power and maintaining global influence is important.	■ Researching how the trade system works to maintain wealth, and thus power and influence, for example the rise of China, Russian gas.
■ Superpower influence extends to the idea of a developing 'global culture' of ideas and norms — for instance ideas of Americanisation and 'McDonaldisation' — which has led to a backlash among some groups.	■ Investigating conflicting views of the rise of global cultural dominance and appreciating the reasons why some players work to undermine this.

3 Superpower futures

Enquiry question: *What are the implications of the continued rise of new superpowers?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ The rise of the BRICs and continued growth in established superpowers, has resource implications in terms of energy, water and land demand; a balance needs to be achieved of the economic benefits — such as poverty reduction — versus the environmental costs.	■ Weighing up the social, economic and environmental costs and benefits of the rise of emerging powers.
■ Shifting power has implications for older core regions such as the EU and USA – in terms of the extent to which they can adapt to the challenges of a new economic order.	■ Examining the economic and political implications for established powers, and the potentially painful transitions for others.
■ Shifting power and the rise of emerging powers, has implications for the majority of the world – continued dependency or new opportunities?	■ Developing an appreciation that emerging powers may present some countries and regions with new opportunities for growth, but that other areas may remain excluded from growth.
■ Shifting power may cause increased tensions between one global culture and another, for example the relationship between the USA/EU and Asia or the Islamic world; this brings with it risk.	■ Weighing up the risks of geopolitical power shifts in terms of cultural or actual conflict as new power structures emerge.